

GHOSTLINE

Mission Storyline — “AMMUNITION DEPOT”

OVERVIEW

A single mission built from five linked sub-phases: Scout, Security, Hostage Identification, Approach, and Finale. The squad, ALPHA, BETA-1, and BETA-2, moves as one formation from start to finish. The mission ends with the destruction of the facility's ammunition room. The hostage identification phase is the mission's core trust-calibration test: the AI must judge whether a figure is a hostage or a hostile, and the player must judge whether the AI's stated confidence is actually earned.

Squad	ALPHA, BETA-1, BETA-2 (single formation throughout)
Objective	Infiltrate the compound, avoid or neutralize security, correctly identify hostages, destroy the ammunition room
Structure	5 phases, 2 turns each, 10 turns total
Target runtime	6 to 7 minutes

STORYLINE

It starts quiet. The squad, ALPHA, BETA-1, and BETA-2, gets word of an enemy compound storing a large amount of weapons and ammunition. Command wants it gone before it can be used. The three robots move in together, side by side, the whole way through. First, they hang back and watch the place from a distance. They check the walls, the gate, and whether the alarm system is on or off. One side of the compound is easy to see and looks safe. The other side is partly blocked from view, so the squad is not fully sure what is waiting there. Once they pick a way in, they have to deal with the guards patrolling the area. Some guards are out in the open and easy to plan around. But one guard is standing behind cover, half hidden, and the squad's AI has to guess who it is without a clear look. This is the first time the squad has to decide whether to trust what the AI is telling them. Inside the compound, the squad finds a room with several people in it. Some of them are innocent people being held there against their will. Others are enemy fighters. The AI has to figure out who is who, and the squad has to decide whether to act on what the AI says. One person in the room is hard to see clearly, half hidden behind furniture, and the AI still sounds sure either way. Getting this wrong means either hurting an innocent person or missing a real threat, so this moment matters the most in the whole mission. As the squad pushes deeper into the compound, machinery and equipment start messing with their sensors. The AI gets confused and unsure, sometimes for no clear reason. The squad has to lean on their own judgment and tools instead of just trusting every number they see. Getting close to the hostages again raises the stakes: is it truly safe to keep moving forward, or should the squad hold back and check first, this is a call the AI cannot fully make on its own. Finally, the squad reaches the ammunition room. The AI suggests a plan for setting the charge and getting out safely, but it does not know everything the squad has learned along the way, like where the hostages ended up or how much damage the squad has taken. The player has to decide whether to follow the AI's plan as is or adjust it based on what they know. In the end, the charge goes off, the ammunition room is destroyed, and the squad gets out. What matters most by the end is not just whether the mission succeeded, but whether the squad trusted the AI at the right times and questioned it when they should have.

PHASE-BY-PHASE BREAKDOWN

PHASE 1 — SCOUT (Turns 1–2)

Objective	Observe the compound from a distance; identify entry points and alarm status.
Turn 1	Clean long-range scan. Alarm system confirmed inactive on this side. HIGH confidence, accurate. Right call: CONFIRM. Teaches WELL CALIBRATED.
Turn 2	North side read is partially obstructed by structure. AI honestly reports LOW confidence. Right call: SEND DRONE to confirm before committing to an entry point.

PHASE 2 — SECURITY (Turns 3–4)

Objective	Move to the breach point while tracking guard patrols.
Turn 3	Patrol pattern is fully visible and confirmed reliable. Clean call to sneak past or engage quietly.
Turn 4	A guard is partially behind cover; sensor read is degraded but the AI still reports confident identification. This is the COMPLACENCY trap: trusting a call on a target that cannot actually be verified.

PHASE 3 — HOSTAGE IDENTIFICATION (core moment) (Turns 5–6)

Objective	Classify figures in the room as hostage or hostile before acting.
Turn 5	Clear thermal and visual match. AI correctly and confidently identifies a hostile. Acting on this is the right, well-calibrated call.
Turn 6	A figure is only partially visible (behind furniture, poor angle). AI still reports HIGH confidence either way. This is the highest-stakes version of the signature mismatch: a wrong call here means killing a hostage or missing a real threat. Right move: ASK WHY or SEND DRONE before firing.

PHASE 4 — APPROACH TO AMMO ROOM (Turns 7–8)

Objective	Move deeper into the facility toward the ammunition room.
Turn 7	Facility EM interference degrades sensors unpredictably. AI confidence swings with no clear cause. Player should rely on own tools rather than trusting any single reading.
Turn 8	A judgment call outside the AI's built-in scope (e.g. whether it is safe to proceed with hostages possibly nearby). AI flags this as outside its parameters. Player must OVERRIDE.

PHASE 5 — FINALE: AMMUNITION ROOM DESTRUCTION (Turns 9–10)

Objective	Set the charge, extract the squad, resolve the mission.
Turn 9	AI recommends detonation timing and an escape route based on squad status, but does not account for something the player knows (e.g. a hostage's actual location, or earlier squad damage). The AI's math is right but incomplete.
Turn 10	Final confirm or override to detonate and extract. Debrief resolves both mission outcome (did the depot go down, did the squad and hostages survive) and trust calibration score across the full mission.

ADDED ELEMENT: FIRE HAZARD

A fire hazard runs through the back half of the mission as an extra layer of pressure, on top of the trust-calibration decisions. During Phase 2 (Security), a stray shot from the guard exchange hits a fuel line or storage crate, and a small fire starts in the background. It is not the squad's main problem yet, but it is now burning somewhere in the compound. By Phase 4 (Approach to Ammo Room), the fire has grown and is producing heat and smoke that interferes with the squad's sensors, this becomes another honest reason the AI's readings get noisy and unreliable, alongside the facility's EM interference. The player sees smoke haze in the environment as a visual cue that something is degrading sensor quality here. By Phase 5 (Finale), the fire has become a ticking clock. It is now spreading toward the ammunition room itself, which means the squad no longer has unlimited time to decide on detonation timing and extraction, waiting too long risks the fire reaching the ammunition before the squad's own charge does, and possibly catching the squad in the compound at the same time. This adds real urgency to the Turn 9 and Turn 10 decisions: the AI's suggested timing may be too slow once the fire is accounted for, or too rushed if it does not know the safest evacuation path around the flames. It becomes one more thing the AI's plan does not fully know, which the player has to notice and correct for.